C2 Writing

Nominalisation for formal writing

Turn verbs and adjectives into nouns for a denser, more academic style, without losing clarity.

Nominalisation turns a process (a verb) or a quality (an adjective) into a noun. It is typical of academic, legal and policy writing because it packs more information into a sentence and shifts the focus from people to ideas.

Verbal style	Nominal style
The company expanded rapidly, which worried investors.	*The company's rapid expansion worried investors.*
Because prices rose, people bought less.	*The rise in prices led to a fall in consumption.*
If we analyse the data carefully, we can see a trend.	*Careful analysis of the data reveals a trend.*
The committee decided to postpone the vote, which surprised members.	*The committee's decision to postpone the vote surprised members.*

Common patterns

Verb or adjective	Noun pattern
increase, reduce	an increase in, a reduction in
fail, refuse	failure to, refusal to
able, willing	the ability to, willingness to
important, available	the importance of, the availability of
develop, depend	the development of, dependence on

Keep one strong verb. Once ideas become nouns, link them with a precise verb: *leads to, results in, reflects, contributes to, accounts for*.

Do not overdo it. Stacked nouns become hard to read: *the implementation of the reduction of costs*. Keep to one or two *of* phrases per noun group: *implementing cost reductions*.

Practice

Rewrite in a nominal style. Question 5 goes the other way.

1. The government failed to act, and this caused public anger.
2. Unemployment increased sharply in 2020.
3. Because the materials were not available, the project was delayed.
4. When people are able to work remotely, they are more satisfied with their jobs.
5. Make lighter: The examination of the reasons for the failure of the introduction of the policy.

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. The government's failure to act caused public anger.
2. There was a sharp increase in unemployment in 2020. / 2020 saw a sharp increase in unemployment.
3. The unavailability of materials delayed the project.
4. The ability to work remotely increases job satisfaction.
5. An examination of why the policy failed when it was introduced.